

state-of-the-art Integrated Community Service Centres (i-CoSC) known as 'SUGAM' have been set up for providing 35 services under one roof to the citizens.

An SMS gateway has been implemented to provide SMS alerts on mobile phones for citizen centric services related to various government departments. Now citizens do not have to visit government offices again and again to find out the status of their applications. A web-based refinc system has also been developed through which movement monitoring of files in the secretariat and other departments is being done. A Revenue Court Monitoring System has been implemented on pilot basis which enables the citizens to find current status of their case and generate cause list on the web.

The State Government has entered into an agreement with private partners to setup 3366 community service centres through which various government and business services will be provided. The state proposes to computerise the urban local bodies to bring more citizen services online. Web-based application for monitoring planning permissions in TCP is being developed for the benefit of citizens. A state level payment gateway and also a call centre are proposed to be set up to enable all citizens to make payments online and also to take assistance through telephone.

The state of Himachal Pradesh is all set on developing an e-procurement application on a PPP model to ensure transparency and efficiency. It has already advertised an offer to developers to set up an integrated IT park-cum-residence at Wakanaghat on PPP Model over 65 acres of land near Solan. A web-based integrated portal offering the services of agriculture, horticulture, animal husbandry, fisheries is ready for launch. Similarly, standard software has been finalised for maintaining accounts of various boards/corporations and the same is being implemented. Computerisation of Public Distribution System (PDS) is being done in pilot districts for efficient and transparent distribution of food grains to the targeted beneficiaries using biometrics and smart card technology. Himachal Pradesh has promised an efficient, transparent and citizen-centric government and ICT is being used as one of the tools towards achieving these goals.

Paradise for Tourists

Geographically diverse in nature, Himachal Pradesh is indeed a paradise for tourists round the year. Lush green valleys, snow covered Himalayan ranges, peaceful environment, rich cultural heritage and hospitality are major attractions. To promote tourism in the countryside and to the lesser-known areas, infrastructure is being developed for the facilitation of the visitors in a phased manner.

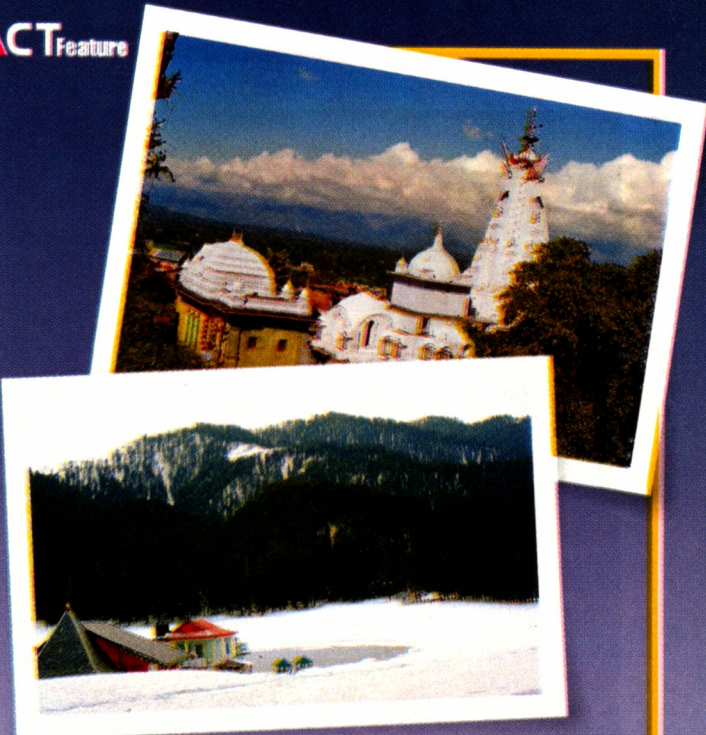
Keeping in view the tremendous tourism potential of the state, the main target areas are promotion of lesser known areas, adventure tourism by way of organisation of events like para gliding, river rafting, trekking, skiing, construction of rope ways, introduction of Heli Taxi service, improvement of civic infrastructure and efforts for night landing facilities in the three existing air fields at Gaggal (Kangra), Bhuntar (Kullu) and Jubberhatti (Shimla). The department is also encouraging private sector investment in tourism sector under public-private partnership (PPP) mode. The Government is also preparing a 20-year perspective Tourism Master Plan. To develop human resource for the hospitality segment, the Government has sanctioned an Institute of Hotel management for Hamirpur district and a food craft institute for Dharamshala in district Kangra. Besides, hospitality courses are introduced in the ITT's at Mandi, Shamshi (Kullu) and Una.

Home Stay Scheme

The State Government has launched the Home Stay Scheme-2008. Under this scheme, registered units are exempted from luxury tax and domestic charges for electricity and water consumption. The purpose of the scheme is to decongest the major tourist destinations and promote new tourism potential in other rural destinations. Presently, there are more than 150 registered home stay units in the state. Rural people have shown a lot of interest in this scheme as it provides them indirect employment at their door step. Besides promoting local handicrafts, the department is also advancing the home stay units through its website: www.himachaltourism.gov.in.

Trekking

The department of tourism had organised a trekking event with the help of Atal Bihari Institute of Mountaineering and Allied Sports, Manali. It was arranged in three districts of



Kullu, Kangra and Shimla in September and October 2009. The routes were Manali-Beaskund, Kharspathar-Ginganga-Kuper-Jubbai and Dharamshala-Triund-Indirahara pass. 83 people from Punjab, Haryana, Chandigarh, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal have participated in it.

To tap the adventure tourism, the department has invited EOI's for ropeways and Heli Taxi services in the state. In the initial phase, three ropeways are to be constructed, namely Kullu-Bijli-Mahadev, Manali-Palchan in Kullu district and Dharamkot-Triund in Kangra district.

Himachal Pradesh is popularly known as 'Winter Paradise'. Winter Carnival is regularly organised by the district administration at Manali and tourism department provides necessary financial and logistic support to such events.

Forthcoming Destinations

The department is developing new tourism sites under circuit and destination schemes, with financial assistance from the Ministry of Tourism. The sites which are being developed are: Manimahesh, Sihunta-Samote in Chamba district, Jogindernagar-Bir-Billing, Chintpurni-Una- Bilaspur, Hamirpur circuit, outer Seraj in Kullu; Solan and Chail; Naldehra, Shimla-Narkanda and Jubbal- Kotkhai in Shimla district and Tribal circuit and Eco tourism circuit in the state. Basic facilities for the visitors like way side amenities, toilets, parking, tourist reception centres, landscaping, construction of resting places, trekking paths and improvement/renovation of temple sites are being developed.

Tourist Data and Employment Generation

The average growth rate of tourists in Himachal Pradesh in the last year is approx. 10 per cent to 15 per cent. Tourist arrivals for last four years are:

YEAR	INDIAN	FOREIGN	TOTAL
2005	69.28 Lacs	2.08 Lacs	71.36 Lacs
2006	76.72 Lacs	2.81 Lacs	79.53 Lacs
2007	84.82 Lacs	3.39 Lacs	88.21 Lacs
2008	93.73 Lacs	3.76 Lacs	97.49 Lacs

